

STREETS OF YOTSUYA

Narrative Design Document – Character Notes

Selected character notes exploring motivation, identity and role within the narrative system.

The following notes cover the principal characters currently defined in development.

Characters marked as in progress are structurally placed within the narrative but remain open in terms of specific details, backstory and voice.

Characters marked as defined have established roles, motivations and functions within the system.

The ensemble is designed around a classic five-person structure roles that complement rather than duplicate each other. Three of the five are currently defined.

01 – The Protagonist

STATUS	Defined — core details established
ROLE	Player character / Agent of consequence
AGE	Mid-twenties
INTRODUCED	Opening sequence — Chapter 0

Identity

The protagonist's gender identity is player-defined and could be male, female or non-binary. The choice does not alter the character's core personality, history or story arc. It shapes how the world reads and responds to them: which doors open easily, which conversations carry different weight, which factions extend trust more readily.

Personality

A natural troublemaker: not malicious, not criminal, but someone who moves fast, reads people quickly and occasionally fails to consider consequences before acting. Instinct over strategy. Improvisation over planning. Passionate about cars and underground drift culture in a way that is less hobby and more identity.

Background

Born and raised in Tokyo. Connected to the city through memory and neighborhood rather than through the underground world they are about to enter. The father, a man with a drinking problem, an easy laugh, and connections that were never fully explained, is the thread that pulls the protagonist into the story. His absence is the inciting condition.

Narrative function

The protagonist is not a hero moving toward resolution. They are an ordinary person moving through a system they do not fully understand, making decisions whose costs accumulate. The player does not win the game. They survive it, or they don't.

Voice

Dry. Reactive. Occasionally funny without trying to be. Does not explain themselves.

02 — Sachi

STATUS	Defined — character established
ROLE	Ally / Physical force / Anchor
AGE	Late twenties — TBD
INTRODUCED	Early game — first major mission

Identity

Sachi is a transgender woman. Before transitioning she used steroids extensively, building a physique that remains with her after the switch: massive, muscular, physically intimidating. She moves like a bully. The body and the name are both deliberate constructions. She decided who to be with the same precision and commitment she brings to everything else. There is no contradiction between her physicality and her identity.

Personality

Loyal once trust is established and difficult to establish trust with. She does not extend it easily or quickly, and she does not explain why. She is direct to the point of bluntness, occasionally to the point of intimidation, and entirely uninterested in softening either. She is not the protagonist's protector. She is their equal: someone who happens to be better at certain things, and expects the same in return.

Relationship with the protagonist

They meet during an early mission. The alliance forms because it is useful, and becomes something more because they are both, in different ways, people who don't fit easily into the world around them. There is no romance. There is loyalty, which in

this world is rarer and worth more.

Narrative function

Sachi represents physical agency in a world where the protagonist's primary resource is perception and instinct. She does not solve problems through cleverness. She solves them through presence. Her arc (still in development) concerns what she has built and what she is willing to risk losing.

Voice

Short sentences. No unnecessary words. Occasionally, without warning, something precise and devastating.

03 — Ryu

STATUS	Defined — character established
ROLE	Ally / Precision / Silent force
AGE	Thirties — TBD
INTRODUCED	Mid game — TBD

Identity

Ryu is a nickname, never explained. He dresses like the 1970s in a 1990s world: deliberately anachronistic, entirely unselfconscious about it. His most recognizable detail is a pair of Rayban sunglasses with a small metal dragon mounted on the upper frame. He is never seen without them.

He is Bronco's son. He inherited his father's respiratory condition: a heavy, audible breathing that worsens with the cigarettes he smokes constantly, as if repeating the same ritual that killed his father is a form of loyalty. He is aware of this. He has never stopped.

The connection between Ryu and the protagonist (through their fathers, through a history neither of them fully knows) is not established at the point they meet. It emerges through the investigative thread that runs beneath the main story. Neither of them is looking for it when they find it.

Personality

Ryu is entirely present: he watches, he calculates, he decides. He simply does not perform any of this. He is never excited, never rattled, never visibly impressed. This makes the rare moments when he moves or speaks with urgency register as genuinely alarming.

His loyalty, once given, is absolute. Getting there takes time and requires the protagonist to demonstrate something worth respecting: not strength, not charm, but consistency.

Reference

Functionally analogous to Jigen Daisuke in Lupin III, the precise, unflappable counterweight to the protagonist's instinct and chaos. Where the protagonist improvises, Ryu prepares. Where Sachi overwhelms, Ryu eliminates.

Narrative function

Ryu introduces a different kind of competence into the ensemble: one built on patience, accuracy and the willingness to do what needs doing without discussion. His connection to the protagonist's past, and the moment when that connection surfaces, is one of the central emotional beats of the investigative thread.

Voice

Minimal. When he speaks it is because silence has run out of usefulness. He does not ask questions he already knows the answer to.

Supporting Characters

The Father

STATUS	Defined — narrative function established
ROLE	Absent presence / Inciting condition
APPEARANCE	Flashback and environmental traces only

The father does not appear in the present timeline. He exists through the protagonist's memory (specifically through the flashback that opens the game) and through the traces he left in the world: debts, connections, and a history with forces the protagonist is only beginning to understand.

He was a man with a drinking problem, an easy laugh, and a relationship with the underground world of Tokyo that was never fully explained to his child. The nature of that relationship is a central investigative thread.

Bronco

STATUS	Defined — role established
ROLE	Emotional anchor / Memory object
APPEARANCE	Flashback only — deceased

The owner of the bar where the protagonist's father drank. Known only by his nickname, Bronco, given for a respiratory condition that made his breathing audible across the room. He died of cancer. His son is Ryu.

In the flashback he is barely visible: a voice, a glowing cigarette tip, a presence behind a wall of smoke. He is remembered through ritual: the large beer, the mango ice pop, the precise choreography of a regular and his barman.

The Hitman

STATUS	In development
ROLE	Antagonist / Inciting threat / Possible connection to the father
APPEARANCE	Opening sequence — Chapter 0

The hitman who enters through a secondary entrance in the opening sequence is a professional. He moves without sound. He is not there by accident.

His connection to the father (whether through the yakuza, through a debt, or through something else entirely) is a narrative thread currently under development. He may be the first thread the protagonist pulls, or he may be a dead end that leads somewhere unexpected.

Ensemble — In Development

The full ensemble is designed around five principal characters. Three are currently defined. Two remain to be developed as the project progresses.

01 — Protagonist	Defined
02 — Sachi	Defined
03 — Ryu	Defined
04 — TBD	In development
05 — TBD	In development

The remaining two roles will be developed in relation to the narrative gaps left by the current ensemble: someone who mediates, and someone who knows things the others don't.